

Monte Verde Criminal Police
Case 1114



Envelope A

The night of the masquerade

Open this envelope first.

- ☐ A1 Letter from the Chief Inspector
- ☐ A2 Crime scene report
- ☐ A3 Crime scene photograph
- ☐ A4 The six suspects
- ☐ A5 Gala programme
- ☐ A6 First interviews
- ☐ A7 Floor plan

Cut out the label along the dashed line and stick it on an envelope, or keep this sheet on top of the pile.

How to work this case

You are two detectives, and this is your case file. The game on your laptop or phone is headquarters: it guards the locked evidence, holds the hints, and hears your final accusation.

Write on everything. Circle times, underline anything that sounds like a lie, cross out suspects, scribble in the margins. Nothing here is precious.

The envelopes

- Envelope A is yours now.
- Envelope B stays sealed until you crack Victor's safe in the game.
- Envelope C stays sealed until you decode Victor's notebook and Chief Inspector Duret answers your call.

Good to know

- Everything in the envelopes is also in the game, so you can zoom in on screen whenever the paper is too small.
- A magnifying glass makes the crime scene photograph more fun. Your phone camera's zoom works too.
- Stuck? The game has three hints for each lock, from gentle to generous.
- When you are both sure, fill in the accusation form together, then enter it in the game to hear the verdict. You only get one.



Monte Verde Criminal Police
Office of the Chief Inspector

Sunday 15 November, 03:10

Dear Detectives _____ and _____,

I'm sorry to call you out at this hour, and sorrier about the reason.

At 00:07 tonight, Victor Valmont was found dead at the desk of his private office above the gaming floor, in the middle of his own party. The Velvet Crown was celebrating forty-five years under his ownership with a masquerade gala: three hundred guests, every one of them in a mask.

His doctor swears it was no heart attack. So do I. The building was sealed at 00:15 and nobody has left since.

Six people had reasons to want him gone, and all six were under this roof. Everything we have so far is in this file. As the lab and my officers bring in more, I'll send it to you in sealed envelopes. Some doors only you can open, though. Victor's safe, for one: the code died with him.

Before dawn I need three answers from you: who killed Victor Valmont, how it was done, and why.

Trust the evidence, not the masks.

Léa Duret

Chief Inspector

Scene report: the Crown Office

Confidential

Location	Crown Office, first floor, Velvet Crown Casino
Reported	00:07, by Marco Santoro, floor manager, who found the body at 00:04
Building sealed	00:15, by casino security at police request
Police on scene	00:19
Victim	Victor Valmont, 67, owner of the casino since 14 November 1981

The body

Seated in the desk chair, slumped forward over the blotter. No wounds and no sign of a struggle. Signs consistent with sudden heart failure; the police surgeon suspects poisoning. Preliminary time of death: between 23:30 and 00:05.

On the desk (numbers match photograph 3)

1. A game of patience (Klondike solitaire) in progress, dealt from a fresh deck.
2. Crystal glass of cognac, about half full.
3. Crystal decanter of cognac, Mr Valmont's private reserve.
4. Ashtray with an unlit cigar.
5. Fountain pen.
6. Framed wedding photograph, Mr and Mrs Valmont, 2016.
7. A book, *The Gambler's Almanac*.
8. Desk lamp.

Elsewhere in the office

- Waste bin: the cellophane wrapper from a pack of casino playing cards. The numbered security seal on it reads **VC-0431**.
- Under the desk blotter, a note in Mr Valmont's handwriting:

| *Nov. – My four oldest friends keep the code. Ask them in the order of my heart.*

- Wall safe behind the painting: locked, four-digit keypad. Mrs Valmont states that only her husband knew the code. The manufacturer cannot send a technician before Monday.
- Door: electronic keycard lock. Log requested from casino security.
- Window: locked from the inside.

Notes

Dr L. Kraus reached the office at 00:12 with Mrs Valmont and announced to everyone present that Mr Valmont had been poisoned. Within half an hour the whole building knew.

At 00:30, asked for her keycard, Mrs Valmont took it from her evening clutch.



Case 1114 Photo 3 Crown Office desk 00:41

The six suspects

Police files. Heights were measured in the shoes each person wore to the gala.



Isabella Valmont

Victor's wife, 41

Height 1.76 m
Mask tonight Silver butterfly
Office keycard Yes

Married Victor in 2016. Former headline singer of the Velvet Crown revue. Sole heir under his current will, written in 2017.

☐ Suspicious ☐ Cleared



Marco Santoro

Floor manager, 55

Height 1.77 m
Mask tonight Black half-mask (staff)
Office keycard Yes

Victor's right hand since 2001. Runs the gaming floor and the nightly count. Delivers the fresh deck for Victor's Last Hand every evening.

☐ Suspicious ☐ Cleared



Dr. Leopold Kraus

Victor's physician, 63

Height 1.71 m
Mask tonight Ivory plague doctor
Office keycard No

Victor's doctor and friend of forty years. An enthusiastic, unlucky gambler. Played the final table tonight. Left his medical bag in the cloakroom.

☐ Suspicious ☐ Cleared



Nikolai Petrov

Rival casino owner, 54

Height 1.95 m

Mask tonight Gilded lion

Office keycard No

Owner of the Aurora Palace across the bay. Has offered to buy the Velvet Crown three times. Played the final table tonight.

☐ Suspicious ☐ Cleared



Celeste Moreau

Resident jazz singer, 31

Height 1.82 m

Mask tonight Black feathers

Office keycard No

Three years into a six-year contract. Headlined the gala and sang a surprise duet with Mrs Valmont.

☐ Suspicious ☐ Cleared



Tobias Grey

Dealer, Salon Privé, 30

Height 1.84 m

Mask tonight Black half-mask (staff)

Office keycard No

Dealer at the Velvet Crown since 2024. Amateur card magician, popular with guests and staff. Deals left-handed. Dealt the final table tonight.

☐ Suspicious ☐ Cleared



The Velvet Crown

Forty-five years

Anniversary Masquerade Gala, Saturday 14 November

-
- 20:30** Doors open. Guests without a mask receive a white Bauta at the entrance.
-
- 21:00** Welcome from Victor Valmont and the anniversary spin of the wheel
-
- 22:00** Celeste Moreau sings *Midnight Blue*, a jazz set in the Grand Salon
-
- 22:45** Final table of the Anniversary Poker Classic, Salon Privé, by invitation
-
- 23:00** A surprise in the Grand Salon
-
- 23:30** Masked auction for the Monte Verde Children's Hospital
-
- 00:00** Unmasking at midnight and a champagne toast

Black tie and masks, please. The house wishes you luck.

**Isabella Valmont***Victor's wife*

Victor opened the night at nine with his speech and the anniversary spin. You should have seen him, like a boy with a new toy.

From a quarter to eleven I watched the final table in the Salon Privé. I'll admit I was there to watch Nikolai play. Even the dealer was in a playful mood: at about ten to eleven he made my wedding ring vanish from my finger, and it turned up in Nikolai's champagne. Everyone laughed. My clutch was right there on the rail beside me.

At five to eleven I slipped backstage. Celeste and I sang the surprise duet from eleven until twenty-five past, and Victor sat in the front row the whole time, grinning. Afterwards he went upstairs for his Last Hand, as he does every night, and I went back to the Salon Privé.

My keycard? In my clutch, where it always is. And no, I don't know the safe code. Victor had his sayings about cards. "Love, work, money, trouble: hearts, spades, diamonds, clubs. That's the order of my heart." He had it engraved on his cigar case.

**Marco Santoro***Floor manager*

Every night since 1981, at half past eleven, Victor plays one hand of solitaire with a brand-new sealed deck. The Last Hand, he calls it. Win it and tomorrow is lucky. The whole staff knows about it.

At 21:55 I signed tonight's deck out of the Cage and took it up at 22:01, same as always. He wasn't in the office. I left it sealed on the blotter and came straight back down.

From 23:05 I was in the Cage with Mirela for the midnight count. At 00:04 I carried the takings upstairs and found him. I called security at once.

He was a superstitious man. He kept four cards from his very first deck, yellow as old piano keys, hidden around that desk. "My oldest friends," he called them. And forty years at the tables, he still licked his thumb before every card he dealt. I never broke him of it.



Dr Leopold Kraus
Victor's physician

Victor and I had words at the bar at about half past ten. About money, if you must know, and it's nobody's business but ours.

From a quarter to eleven I played the final table of the Poker Classic. I didn't leave my seat until after midnight. Ask anyone at that table.

I've been Victor's doctor for thirty years. His heart was as strong as an ox's. That's why I said it the moment I saw him: this was no natural death. Somebody poisoned him.



Nikolai Petrov
Rival casino owner

I came to play cards, Inspector, not to kill my competition. Yes, I offered Victor sixty million for this old palace. Yes, he laughed in my face. Three times.

From 22:45 I sat at the final table. I was chip leader by midnight; you can check. I barely saw Victor all evening. He was downstairs, watching his wife sing.

Why would I need him dead? With the Aurora Palace across the bay, the Velvet Crown was dying on its own.



Celeste Moreau
Resident jazz singer

My first set ran from ten until a quarter to eleven. Then I rested in my dressing room until the duet with Isabella: eleven until about twenty-five past, in front of three hundred people. After that I stayed backstage until the unmasking.

Victor held my contract like a leash. Three more years. But I sing for a living, Inspector. I don't poison old men.

My father was a performer too, you know. He died when I was nine. I've had enough death for one life.

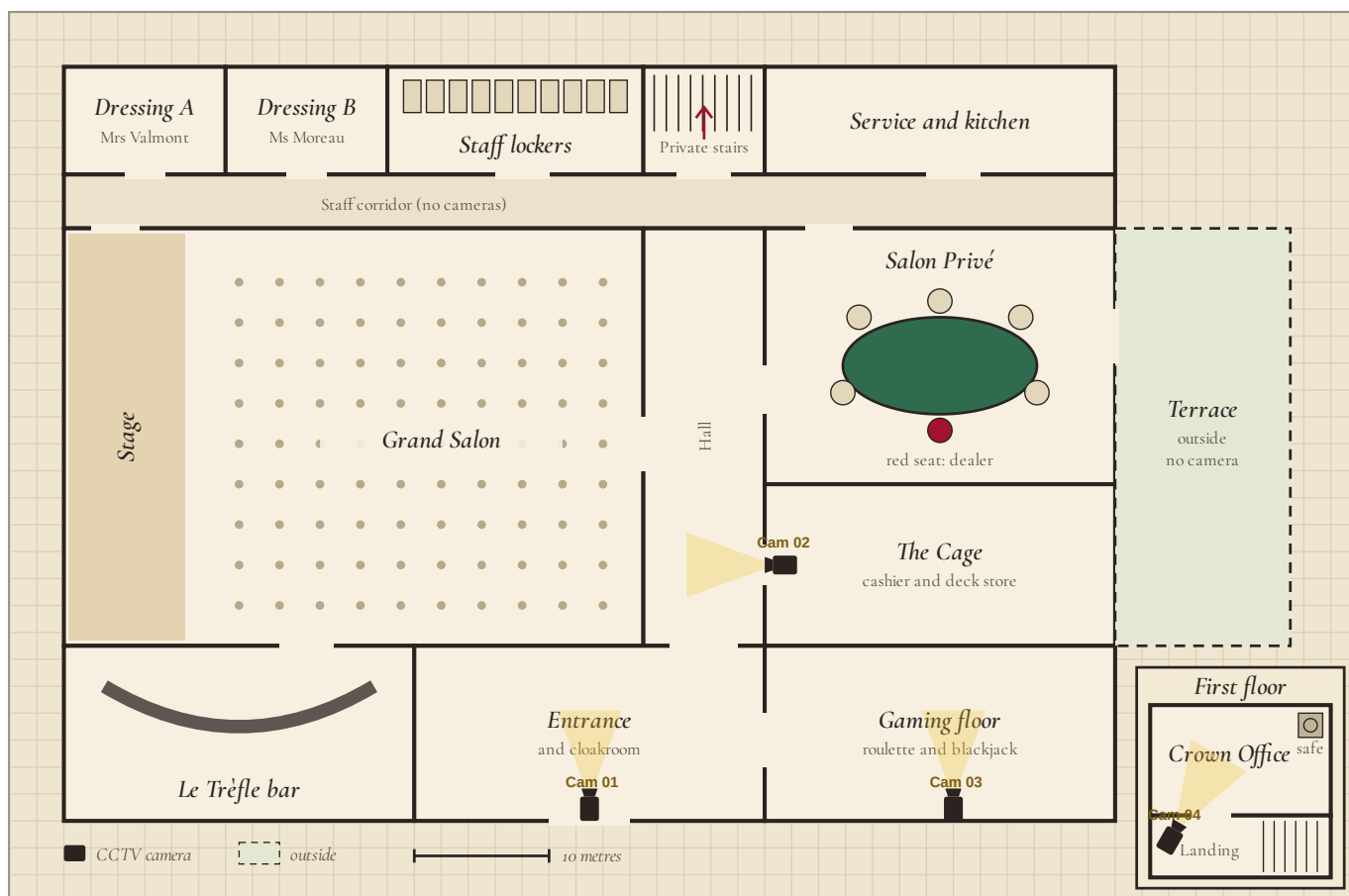


Tobias Grey
Dealer, Salon Privé

I dealt the final table from a quarter to eleven. My break was 23:05 to 23:20. I went out onto the terrace for a cigarette and some air; the Salon gets hot with all those masks. Nobody saw me, I suppose. It was just me and the sea.

Mr Valmont tipped well and remembered everyone's name. Beyond that I hardly knew him.

The ring? A little trick for Mrs Valmont. Guests like a bit of magic with their cards. It's good for tips.



Notes from the scene officer

The Crown Office can only be reached by the private stairs from the staff corridor. Camera 04 watches the landing outside the office door.

Walking times, measured tonight: Salon Privé to the office door by the staff corridor, 40 seconds. Stage to the office door, 55 seconds. Terrace to the Salon Privé, 30 seconds.

There are no cameras in the staff corridor, in the Salon Privé or on the terrace.